

Which parameters matter for which kind of automotive website

A parameter-by-parameter importance matrix across the four automotive website types the platform audits, derived from the 164 parameters currently implemented in [Backend/metricServices/](#) — with the reasoning behind every rating, the recommended section-weight profile per type, and the coverage gaps the engine has today.

1. Car Dealership

franchise / OEM new-car store

2. Automotive Dealer

independent / used-car lot

3. Automotive Service

service centre / chain

4. Mechanical / Repair

garage, body shop

164 parameters · 8 sections · 4 site types · 98 shared core · 23 that swing two levels or more · 12 inapplicable somewhere

Source of truth: implemented parameter returns in [technicalMetrics](#), [seoMetrics](#), [accessibilityMetrics](#), [securityCompliance](#), [uxContentStructure](#), [conversionLeadFlow](#), [aioReadiness](#), [aioService](#)

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PART 1

How to read this report

Every parameter the engine implements is rated against each of the four automotive website types on a three-level scale. A rating is not a statement about how good a parameter is — it is a statement about how much that parameter moves the outcome *for that kind of business*.

✓✓✓ Most Important

Fix first. Either a hard gate, or the parameter that carries this site type's primary revenue mechanism. Failing it costs measurable business.

✓✓ Important

Materially weighted. Meaningfully affects ranking, conversion or compliance for this type, but is not the thing the site lives or dies on.

✓ Recommended

Measure it and fix it when convenient. Real but low leverage for this type — usually diagnostic or polish.

– Not applicable

This site type has no page that carries the parameter. It is dropped from the denominator, never scored zero.

The N/A rule is the most important one here. A parameter that does not apply must be renormalised out of the score, not counted as a failure. A repair shop with no vehicle inventory scoring zero on Vehicle Image Gallery, Trade-In Flow and VDP Content Uniqueness is the single largest source of false-low scores in any audit product — and today all four of these site types resolve to the same internal siteType: "dealer", so that is exactly what happens.

• The four types, as used in this report

“Car dealership” and “automotive dealer” are used interchangeably in everyday language. To make two separate columns meaningful they are split here on the one distinction that actually changes the parameter set: **franchise versus independent**. If you read them as synonyms, columns 1 and 2 collapse — and the 22 parameters where they differ are precisely the franchise-versus-independent differences.

COLUMN 1

Car Dealership — franchise / OEM new-car store

Manufacturer-appointed dealer. New, used and certified pre-owned inventory on one site.

- 5,000–50,000 URLs; thousands of VDPs, faceted SRPs
- Lease specials and advertised APR → Reg-Z / Reg-M exposure
- Credit application, payment calculator, trade valuation
- Full service department and parts counter
- Dealer.com / DealerOn / Dealer Inspire / CDK platforms

COLUMN 2

Automotive Dealer — independent / used-car lot

No manufacturer franchise. Mixed-brand used inventory, often feed-supplied.

- 50–500 VDPs; far smaller crawl surface
- No OEM incentives or lease programmes; subprime and buy-here-pay-here finance
- FTC CARS Rule is the primary compliance exposure
- Usually no service department
- No brand halo → reviews, history reports and real photos do the trust work

COLUMN 3

Automotive Service — service centre or chain

Servicing, tyres, fast-fit, dealership service microsites. No vehicle sales.

- No inventory at all → a whole block of parameters is N/A
- The funnel is a booking scheduler, not a lead form
- Service menu, published pricing, coupons and seasonal offers
- Multi-location → local landing pages, NAP, Google Business Profile
- Repeat-customer business; loyalty and reminders matter

COLUMN 4

Mechanical / Vehicle Repair — garage, body shop

Independent mechanic, collision repair, specialist or mobile mechanic.

- 10–40 pages, single location, frequently self-built
- The conversion is a phone call — click-to-call is the funnel
- Trust is technician credentials and accreditation, not brand
- Demand is symptom-driven and answered increasingly by AI, not links
- Highest incidence of basic hygiene failures: HTTPS, mobile, accessibility

What the matrix actually says

164

implemented parameters rated

98

Important or above for *all four* —
the shared core (60%)

23

swing by two levels or more

12

genuinely N/A for at least one
type

- 60% of the parameter set does not care what kind of automotive business it is.** 98 of 164 parameters rate Important or Most Important for all four types — Core Web Vitals, HTTPS, certificate validity, reputation, titles, H1, contrast, mobile experience, CTA clarity, schema validity, server-rendered content, AI bot access. 63 of them carry an *identical* rating in all four columns. The shared core is the product; the site type is a tilt on top of it.
- Only 23 parameters swing by two levels or more, and 12 of those are pure applicability.** 78 more differ by exactly one level — a tilt, not a different job. Strip out the N/A cases and just 11 parameters genuinely change character between site types: title and description uniqueness, canonicals, internal linking (all four are the same scale problem), CSP, Reg-Z/Reg-M disclaimers, breadcrumbs, CTA crowding, AI-friendly linking, and appointment booking — the only one that runs the other way, from Important on a franchise site to Most Important on a garage.
- 12 parameters are genuinely inapplicable somewhere, and every one of them is inventory-scoped.** Sold-vehicle handling, VDP uniqueness, SRP index control, SRP→VDP links, inventory filtering, no-results UX, vehicle gallery, vehicle history, trade-in flow, financing flow, finance calculator and finance-form security exist only where vehicles are sold. On a service or repair site they must be renormalised out, not scored zero. This is the whole ball game — scoring these as failures would cost a garage roughly a section and a half of its total score.
- The differences concentrate in three sections.** Conversion & Lead Flow (26 of 33 rows differ), Security & Compliance (15 of 25) and On-Page SEO (13 of 22). Technical Performance (7 of 15) and Accessibility (10 of 24) are nearly flat, because physics and WCAG do not care about business model.
- Franchise versus independent is a smaller distinction than either is from service.** Columns 1 and 2 differ on 22 parameters; service and repair differ on 30; but 75 parameters separate the two selling types from the two servicing types. If you only ever build two profiles, build *sells vehicles* and *services vehicles*.
- Compliance is the sharpest split, and it is not about site quality.** Anyone taking a credit application is handling SSNs under the GLBA Safeguards Rule; anyone advertising APR or a lease payment is under Reg-Z / Reg-M; independent lots are the FTC CARS Rule's primary target. A garage advertising a \$99 brake service carries almost none of that load — which is why Security & Compliance should weigh 13% on a dealer site and 8–9% on a repair site.
- AEO inverts the usual hierarchy.** Service and repair rate higher than dealers on answer-first structure, FAQ blocks, topical authority, E-E-A-T and per-engine platform scores. Their customers ask questions AI engines now answer directly, and a local business with no brand equity gains the most from being the cited source. Dealers gain from schema and index coverage — being present as structured inventory — more than from being quoted.
- Trust inverts too.** Testimonials, trust badges, certifications, vehicle history reports and partner logos all rate *higher* for independents, service and repair than for franchise dealers. A franchise store borrows the manufacturer's credibility; nobody else can.
- The engine cannot currently act on any of this.** `siteTypeDetector` returns only dealer, corporate or unknown. All four types collapse to dealer, so a garage is scored against a franchise dealer's expectations. Seven concrete coverage gaps follow in Part 6.

• The six drivers behind every rating

No cell in the matrix is a matter of taste. Every rating that differs between columns traces to one of six structural differences between the businesses. The driver codes appear against each row in Part 5.

D1 Page inventory

Does the site actually contain the page type that carries this parameter? A VDP-scoped check cannot matter on a site with no VDPs — it is N/A, not low-priority. This is the single biggest source of difference between the four columns.

D2 Conversion mechanism

How a lead is actually captured. Franchise and independent dealers convert through forms (ePrice, trade valuation, credit app). Service converts through a booking scheduler. Repair converts through a phone call. Whatever carries the lead gets the weight.

D3 Regulatory exposure

Advertised finance/lease terms and collected PII. Reg-Z / Reg-M / FTC CARS Rule / GLBA Safeguards apply to anyone advertising APR or taking a credit application; a repair shop advertising a \$99 brake service carries almost none of that load.

D4 Site scale

Crawl budget, index bloat, duplicate content and template consistency are functions of URL count. A 40,000-URL franchise site and a 15-page garage site have opposite failure modes — one drowns in near-duplicates, the other has too little to index.

D5 Trust deficit

A franchise dealer borrows credibility from the OEM badge. An independent lot, a service chain and a garage have no such halo, so reviews, credentials, real photos and transparent pricing have to do that work directly.

D6 Query intent in AI answers

Dealers are found through transactional inventory queries ('2022 RAV4 under \$30k near me'). Service and repair are found through informational and symptom queries ('why is my car shaking', 'timing belt cost') — exactly the queries AI answer engines answer instead of ranking links for.

PART 3

The master matrix

All 164 implemented parameters, grouped by audit section. ✓✓✓ Most Important · ✓✓ Important · ✓ Recommended · – not applicable. A **GAP** tag means the engine does not currently measure that parameter for at least one site type where this matrix says it matters — see Part 6.

A Technical Performance 18% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
LCP — Largest Contentful Paint	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
CLS — Cumulative Layout Shift	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
INP / TBT — interaction responsiveness	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
FCP — First Contentful Paint	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
TTFB — Time To First Byte	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Speed Index	✓	✓	✓	✓
Total Blocking Time	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Render-blocking resources	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓
Resource optimisation (images/JS/CSS)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Compression (Brotli/Gzip)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Caching policy	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Redirect chains	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Sold-vehicle / soft-404 handling	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	—	—
PageSpeed / Lighthouse headline score (info)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Delivery hygiene composite (info)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

B On-Page SEO 17% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Meta title	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Title uniqueness (cross-page)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓
Title location optimisation	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Meta description	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Meta description uniqueness	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
URL structure	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
URL slugs	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Canonical tag	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓
H1	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Heading hierarchy	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Image optimisation (SEO view)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Semantic tags / HTML5 landmarks	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Internal link profile	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Content relevance (title↔H1↔body)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Robots.txt / index intent	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Open Graph tags	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Twitter card	✓	✓	✓	✓
Social profile links / sameAs	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Viewport meta	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
VDP content uniqueness (vs OEM boilerplate)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	—	—
SRP pagination & faceted index control	✓✓✓	✓✓	—	—
SRP → VDP internal links	✓✓✓	✓✓	—	—

C Accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA) 8–11% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
WCAG 2.2 AA aggregate	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Colour contrast	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Form labels	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓
HTML lang attribute	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Keyboard navigation	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Focus order / focusable content / tabindex / aria-hidden focus	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Image alt text	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Link name	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Button name	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
ARIA roles	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
ARIA allowed attributes	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Document title	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Meta viewport (zoom not disabled)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Target size (WCAG 2.2, 2.5.8)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Reflow at 320px / 400% zoom	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Heading order	✓	✓	✓	✓
Landmarks	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
List markup	✓	✓	✓	✓
Skip links	✓	✓	✓	✓
Interactive element affordance	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Text spacing (info)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Focus not obscured (info)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Prefers-reduced-motion (info)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Legal frameworks — ADA / §508 / DDA / EAA / AODA (info)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

D Security & Compliance 8–22% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
HTTPS + no mixed content	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
SSL certificate validity	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
SSL expiry window	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
TLS version	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
HSTS	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Content-Security-Policy	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
X-Frame-Options / frame-ancestors	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
X-Content-Type-Options	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Referrer-Policy	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Permissions-Policy	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cookie flags (Secure/HttpOnly/SameSite)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Third-party cookies	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Reputation — Safe Browsing / VirusTotal / blacklist	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
SQL-injection surface indicator	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
XSS surface indicator	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Forms use HTTPS	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓
Weak default credentials	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Admin panel public exposure	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓
MFA posture	✓	✓	✓	✓
Cookie consent banner	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Privacy policy link	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
GDPR / CCPA / Do-Not-Sell disclosure	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Finance-form PII security	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	—	—
Legal / financial disclaimers (Reg-Z, Reg-M, FTC CARS)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓
Header security grade (info)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

E UX & Content Structure 9–15% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Text readability	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Intrusive interstitials	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Navigation discoverability	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Above-the-fold content	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Broken links	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Mobile experience	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Interactive click feedback	✓	✓	✓	✓
Loading feedback	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Hierarchy & flow clarity	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Content density balance	✓	✓	✓	✓
Layout consistency	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Sticky-header height	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
In-page navigation (anchors, back-to-top)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Breadcrumbs	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Inventory filtering usability	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	—	—
No-results UX	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	—	—

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Vehicle image gallery quality	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	–	–

F

Conversion & Lead Flow
 7–22% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
CTA presence / visibility	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
CTA clarity / messaging	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
CTA crowding	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓
CTA flow alignment / funnel placement	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Form presence	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓
Form length / field count	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Required vs optional fields	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Inline validation	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Submit-button clarity	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Multi-step form progress	✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Friendly error handling	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Microcopy clarity	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Thank-you page / lead confirmation	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Trust badges	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Testimonials	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Reviews / ratings visibility	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Client / partner logos	✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Case studies / success stories	✓	✓	✓	✓✓
Certifications & awards	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Pricing transparency GAP	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Vehicle history report (CARFAX / AutoCheck)	✓✓	✓✓✓	–	–
Click-to-call	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Chat experience	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Lead magnets	✓	✓	✓	✓
GA4 installed	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓
GTM configuration	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Conversion tracking	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓
CRM integration	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Trade-in flow / valuation tool	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	–	–
Financing flow / pre-approval	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	–	–
Finance / payment calculator	✓✓✓	✓✓	–	–
Appointment booking scheduler	✓✓	✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Incentives / specials displayed	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓

G

AIO — AI Optimisation (ingestion)
 7–10% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Structured-data validity	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Content NLP-friendly (server-rendered, semantic)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Answer-oriented structure	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Keywords / entities annotated	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Content updated regularly / freshness markers	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Internal linking AI-friendly (crawlable anchors)	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Topical focus clarity	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
AI agentic browsing / WebMCP readiness	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓
Duplicate-content readiness (info)	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓
Structured content — lists & tables (info)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Terminology consistency (info)	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓

H AEO — Answer Engine Optimisation 9–14% base

PARAMETER	CAR DEALERSHIP	AUTOMOTIVE DEALER	AUTOMOTIVE SERVICE	MECHANICAL / REPAIR
Schema markup (page-appropriate type)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Answer-first structure / TL;DR lead	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Bot access (GPTBot, Google-Extended, PerplexityBot)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Structured content (tables / lists)	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
FAQ / Q&A blocks + FAQPage schema	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Entity recognition (Organization / LocalBusiness)	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Citation / NAP consistency	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Citations / outbound attribution	✓	✓	✓✓	✓✓
Topical authority / clustering	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
Index coverage	✓✓✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
sameAs validation	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
E-E-A-T composite	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓
llms.txt	✓	✓	✓	✓
Brand entity strength (info)	✓	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓
Markdown headers / clear heading structure (info)	✓	✓	✓✓	✓✓
Page-speed signal in AEO (info)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Platform scores — Gemini / ChatGPT / Perplexity	✓✓	✓✓	✓✓✓	✓✓✓

Column definitions in Part 1. Ratings are per site type, not per page — a parameter marked Most Important still only runs on the page types that carry it.

Where the weight sits

• The 23 parameters that actually swing

Every row in the matrix that moves two or more levels between site types. If you only read one table in this report, read this one — it is the entire practical difference between auditing a franchise dealership and auditing a garage.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHAT THE SWING IS
Sold-vehicle / soft-404 handling Technical Performance	3 3 - -	Only exists where VDPs expire. Inventory churn creates thousands of dead VINs a year, and a soft-404 (200 with 'no longer available') burns crawl budget silently. Nothing on a service or repair site expires this way. D1
Title uniqueness (cross-page) On-Page SEO	3 3 2 1	Templated dealer titles duplicate across thousands of VDPs — the classic dealer-platform defect. A 15-page repair site cannot generate enough pages to have a duplication problem. D4
Meta description uniqueness On-Page SEO	3 2 1 1	Same scale logic as title uniqueness — OEM-boilerplate descriptions repeated across a large VDP set are a real problem only at franchise scale. D4
Canonical tag On-Page SEO	3 3 2 1	The primary defence against faceted-SRP duplicate content. On a franchise site every filter combination is a potential near-duplicate URL. A garage with 15 pages has almost nothing to canonicalise. D4
Internal link profile On-Page SEO	3 2 2 1	Crawl-depth-to-inventory is a real ranking constraint at 40,000 URLs. On a 15-page site every page is one click from the home page regardless. D4
VDP content uniqueness (vs OEM boilerplate) On-Page SEO	3 3 - -	The single biggest VDP ranking killer: thousands of pages carrying identical manufacturer copy. Independent lots suffer it too, from feed-supplied descriptions. No VDPs on service/repair sites. D1
SRP pagination & faceted index control On-Page SEO	3 2 - -	Index bloat scales with facet count multiplied by inventory size, so a franchise store with 20 filters and 900 vehicles is exposed far more than a lot with 4 filters and 60 vehicles. D1 · D4
SRP → VDP internal links On-Page SEO	3 2 - -	Crawl path to inventory. Critical at franchise scale; a 60-car lot's whole inventory fits on one page. D1 · D4
Content-Security-Policy Security & Compliance	3 2 2 1	Franchise dealer sites run the heaviest third-party tag stack in local retail — chat, CRM, inventory widget, trade tool, several tag managers — so the injection surface is genuinely largest there, and it sits on the same origin as the credit application. D3 · D4
Finance-form PII security Security & Compliance	3 3 - -	SSN and income fields must be HTTPS POST, never in a GET query string, with no sensitive autocomplete leakage. Both dealer types run credit applications; neither service nor repair collects this class of data. D1 · D3
Legal / financial disclaimers (Reg-Z, Reg-M, FTC CARS) Security & Compliance	3 3 2 1	Franchise dealers advertise APR and lease terms and are directly exposed to Reg-Z and Reg-M. Independent lots are the primary target of the FTC's CARS Rule on advertised pricing and add-ons. Service coupons need only T&Cs; repair shops rarely advertise credit terms at all. D3
Breadcrumbs UX & Content Structure	3 2 2 1	Depth navigation and BreadcrumbList schema matter most where the path is Home → SRP → filtered SRP → VDP. A garage's deepest path is two levels. D4
Inventory filtering usability UX & Content Structure	3 3 - -	The core task on an SRP: filter clarity, applied-filter visibility, live result counts, clear-all and URL-stable filters. No inventory means no filters. D1
No-results UX UX & Content Structure	3 3 - -	Rated equally high for independents specifically because a small lot hits zero-result searches far more often than a 900-car franchise store — recovering that dead end into a lead is worth more, not less. D1
Vehicle image gallery quality UX & Content Structure	3 3 - -	Photo count, resolution and real-versus-stock detection. For an independent used lot this is the strongest available trust signal — stock manufacturer photography on a used car reads as concealment. D1 · D5
CTA crowding Conversion & Lead Flow	3 3 2 1	A dealer VDP routinely presents eight competing primary CTAs in one viewport — value trade, get ePrice, check availability, schedule test drive, apply for finance, calculate payment, chat, call. Choice paralysis is a dealer-specific disease. D2
Vehicle history report (CARFAX / AutoCheck) Conversion & Lead Flow	2 3 - -	Rated higher for independent lots than franchise stores: with no manufacturer-certified pre-owned programme to point at, a VIN-specific history report is the primary objection handler. D5
Trade-in flow / valuation tool Conversion & Lead Flow	3 3 - -	The reason the trade-in page exists, and one of the two highest-intent lead types in retail automotive. Absent by definition on service and repair. D1 · D2

Site Type	Technical	On-Page SEO	Accessibility	Security	UX & Content	Conversion	AIO	AEO
Car Dealership (franchise)	18	18	9	13	11	17	7	7
Balanced retail profile. Security carries the finance/lease compliance load; Conversion carries the multi-tool funnel.								
Automotive Dealer (independent)	18	17	9	13	12	18	6	7
Conversion up and On-Page slightly down versus franchise: fewer pages to optimise, more weight on turning a smaller audience into leads.								

SITE TYPE	TECHNICAL	ON-PAGE SEO	ACCESSIBILITY	SECURITY	UX & CONTENT	CONVERSION	AIO	AEO
Automotive Service	16	16	9	9	13	19	7	11
Security down (no credit applications), Conversion and AEO up. Booking is the funnel and answer engines are a primary discovery surface.								
Mechanical / Vehicle Repair	16	15	9	8	14	18	7	13
Highest AEO weight of the four and the lowest Security. Discovery is local and question-driven; the conversion is a phone call.								

Read alongside the page tilt, not instead of it. A franchise dealer's Finance page should still carry the existing 22% Security page tilt. The site-type profile above sets the baseline the page tilt moves around — so a repair site's contact page never inherits a franchise dealer's compliance weighting in the first place.

Why every row is rated the way it is

One line per parameter, with the driver codes from Part 2. The pattern column reads left to right as columns 1–4: **3** Most Important, **2** Important, **1** Recommended, **-** not applicable.

A Technical Performance

Almost flat across all four types — Core Web Vitals are a universal ranking and bounce signal and nobody escapes them. The differences are entirely about payload shape and page churn: inventory sites carry 30–50 image galleries and heavy third-party tag stacks (D4), repair sites carry DIY page-builder bloat, and only inventory sites have URLs that die.

PARAMETER	1	2	3	4	WHY THIS PATTERN
LCP — Largest Contentful Paint	3	3	3	3	Universal. Hero + gallery makes it the most-failed metric on dealer VDPs; on service/repair it is usually a single unoptimised hero image. Same weight, different root cause. D4
CLS — Cumulative Layout Shift	3	3	2	2	On a VDP a shift under a finger moves 'Check Availability' — a lost lead. Dealer templates inject sale banners, price disclaimers and chat widgets late. Service/repair layouts are simpler and shift less. D2 · D4
INP / TBT — interaction responsiveness	3	3	2	2	Dealer platforms load chat, CRM, inventory widget, trade tool and 2–3 tag managers on one page — the classic INP killer. Repair sites rarely have more than one script. D4
FCP — First Contentful Paint	2	2	2	2	Supporting CWV, same value everywhere. Perceived-speed proxy, no site-type sensitivity.
TTFB — Time To First Byte	3	3	2	2	On dealer sites the SRP is a live database query against an inventory feed, so origin latency is the upstream cause of every other metric. Service/repair pages are largely static. D4
Speed Index	1	1	1	1	Lab-only perceived-completeness proxy. Diagnostic value everywhere, decision value nowhere.
Total Blocking Time	2	2	2	2	Lab arm of INP. Rated alongside it and never weighted twice.
Render-blocking resources	2	2	2	3	Highest leverage on repair sites: Wix / GoDaddy / stacked WordPress themes ship several synchronous stylesheets and scripts in the head, and removing them is usually the single biggest speed win available. D4
Resource optimisation (images/JS/CSS)	3	3	2	2	A VDP with 40 full-resolution photos is the dominant byte cost in the whole industry. Service and repair pages carry a fraction of that payload. D1 · D4
Compression (Brotli/Gzip)	2	2	2	2	Cheap, universal, one server setting. No site-type sensitivity.
Caching policy	2	2	2	2	Universal. Slight edge to inventory sites because fingerprinted asset volume is larger.
Redirect chains	2	2	1	1	Inventory churn plus platform migrations stack http→https→www→path→new-VDP cascades on dealer sites. A 15-page garage site rarely accumulates hops. D4
Sold-vehicle / soft-404 handling	3	3	-	-	Only exists where VDPs expire. Inventory churn creates thousands of dead VINs a year, and a soft-404 (200 with 'no longer available') burns crawl budget silently. Nothing on a service or repair site expires this way. D1
PageSpeed / Lighthouse headline score (info)	2	2	2	2	Reporting surface, not an independent control. Same everywhere.
Delivery hygiene composite (info)	2	2	2	2	Rolls up TTFB, render-blocking, assets, compression, caching, redirects. Informational in all four.

B On-Page SEO

The widest spread of any section, and almost all of it is scale (D4) versus locality (D6). Franchise dealers fight duplicate-content and index-bloat problems that a garage physically cannot have; garages and service centres fight for geo-modified queries that a franchise dealer often wins by brand alone.

PARAMETER	1	2	3	4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Meta title	3	3	3	3	Primary relevance and CTR signal on every site type. The only universal Critical in this section.
Title uniqueness (cross-page)	3	3	2	1	Templated dealer titles duplicate across thousands of VDPs — the classic dealer-platform defect. A 15-page repair site cannot generate enough pages to have a duplication problem. D4
Title location optimisation	2	3	3	3	Franchise dealers usually rank on brand+geo almost by default ('Toyota dealer Brisbane'). Independent lots, service centres and garages compete against 20 identical local businesses, so the geo modifier IS the ranking battleground. D6

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Meta description	2 2 2 2	CTR lever, not a ranking factor. Equal value everywhere.
Meta description uniqueness	3 2 1 1	Same scale logic as title uniqueness — OEM-boilerplate descriptions repeated across a large VDP set are a real problem only at franchise scale. D4
URL structure	2 2 2 2	Depth, extensions, IDs and length. Consistent value across types.
URL slugs	2 2 2 2	Descriptive, keyword-bearing slugs help everywhere; dealer platforms are the worst offenders with opaque stock IDs.
Canonical tag	3 3 2 1	The primary defence against faceted-SRP duplicate content. On a franchise site every filter combination is a potential near-duplicate URL. A garage with 15 pages has almost nothing to canonicalise. D4
H1	3 3 3 3	One descriptive H1 per page. Universal, and universally broken on page-builder sites.
Heading hierarchy	2 2 2 2	Structural clarity for both crawlers and screen readers. Flat across types.
Image optimisation (SEO view)	3 3 2 2	Alt coverage, next-gen formats and descriptive filenames matter proportionally to image count — and VDP galleries dominate that count. D1
Semantic tags / HTML5 landmarks	2 2 2 2	Shared evidence with Accessibility landmarks. Same value everywhere.
Internal link profile	3 2 2 1	Crawl-depth-to-inventory is a real ranking constraint at 40,000 URLs. On a 15-page site every page is one click from the home page regardless. D4
Content relevance (title↔H1↔body)	2 2 3 3	Dealers win on inventory match; service and repair win on written explanation of the problem and fix, so topic agreement between title, heading and body carries more of the ranking. D6
Robots.txt / index intent	3 3 2 2	An accidental noindex on money pages, or /inventory blocked in robots.txt, is catastrophic and invisible to users. The blast radius scales with the number of pages behind the rule. D4
Open Graph tags	2 2 2 2	Controls social and AI-card rendering. Equal value; often entirely absent on all four.
Twitter card	1 1 1 1	Marginal incremental value over Open Graph in every case.
Social profile links / sameAs	2 2 3 3	Entity disambiguation. A franchise dealer is already resolvable via the OEM's dealer locator; a garage named 'Precision Auto' needs the GBP↔Facebook↔Yelp chain to be identified at all. D5 · D6
Viewport meta	2 2 3 3	Service and repair traffic is overwhelmingly mobile and often urgent ('mechanic near me' from the roadside), so a missing or zoom-locked viewport costs proportionally more. D2
VDP content uniqueness (vs OEM boilerplate)	3 3 - -	The single biggest VDP ranking killer: thousands of pages carrying identical manufacturer copy. Independent lots suffer it too, from feed-supplied descriptions. No VDPs on service/repair sites. D1
SRP pagination & faceted index control	3 2 - -	Index bloat scales with facet count multiplied by inventory size, so a franchise store with 20 filters and 900 vehicles is exposed far more than a lot with 4 filters and 60 vehicles. D1 · D4
SRP → VDP internal links	3 2 - -	Crawl path to inventory. Critical at franchise scale; a 60-car lot's whole inventory fits on one page. D1 · D4

C Accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA)

Legally, not commercially, differentiated. Car dealership websites are one of the most-sued verticals under ADA Title III in the US, and any page that collects financial PII makes a missing label or a contrast failure a blocking defect rather than a cosmetic one. Mobile-first criteria (target size, zoom) flip to critical on service and repair, whose traffic is phone-dominated.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
WCAG 2.2 AA aggregate	3 3 2 2	Litigation exposure is materially higher for dealership websites; service and repair sites are sued far less often, though the obligation is identical. D3
Colour contrast	3 3 3 3	The most-cited automated violation on every site type, and the one most likely to affect a real user reading a price or a phone number.
Form labels	3 3 3 2	On a credit application an unlabelled field is a blocking failure on a PII form. Service booking forms are close behind. Many repair sites have no form at all — just a phone number. D2 · D3
HTML lang attribute	2 2 2 2	Binary, trivial to fix, screen-reader prerequisite. Same everywhere.
Keyboard navigation	3 3 2 2	A keyboard-trapped multi-step credit application or trade valuator locks a user out of the conversion entirely. Simpler sites have less to trap. D2
Focus order / focusable content / tabindex / aria-hidden focus	2 2 2 1	Sub-parts of keyboard navigation. Weighted through the parent, shown individually for diagnosis.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Image alt text	3 3 2 2	Proportional to image count — a VDP gallery can carry 40 images with no alt, which is simultaneously an accessibility and an indexing failure. D1
Link name	2 2 2 2	Icon-only nav and 'read more' links. Flat across types.
Button name	2 2 2 2	Discernible accessible names on controls. Flat across types.
ARIA roles	2 2 2 1	Misuse rises with widget complexity, which rises with inventory tooling.
ARIA allowed attributes	2 2 2 1	Same reasoning as ARIA roles.
Document title	2 2 2 2	Present, unique, descriptive. Overlaps the SEO title check; measured once.
Meta viewport (zoom not disabled)	2 2 3 3	Disabling zoom on a mobile-dominant, often older customer base is a direct barrier. Service and repair skew both mobile and older. D2
Target size (WCAG 2.2, 2.5.8)	2 2 3 3	The 'Book' and 'Call' buttons are the entire funnel on service and repair, and they are usually tapped one-handed on a phone. A sub-24px tap target loses the lead. D2
Reflow at 320px / 400% zoom	2 2 2 2	Horizontal-scroll failures affect all four equally.
Heading order	1 1 1 1	Moderate tier. Fix it, but it rarely blocks a user.
Landmarks	2 2 2 2	One main, plus nav/header/footer. Shared evidence with semantic structure.
List markup	1 1 1 1	Real ul/ol/li rather than faux lists. Moderate tier everywhere.
Skip links	1 1 1 1	Most valuable behind long navigation, which favours dealers marginally.
Interactive element affordance	2 2 2 2	Div-buttons with no role. Equally common on all four.
Text spacing (info)	1 1 1 1	WCAG 2.2 probe, informational, no weight.
Focus not obscured (info)	1 1 1 1	Ties to sticky-header height; informational.
Prefers-reduced-motion (info)	1 1 1 1	Informational probe; hero carousels on dealer sites are the usual offender.
Legal frameworks — ADA / §508 / DDA / EAA / AODA (info)	3 3 2 2	Re-slice of the same axe results per jurisdiction. Rated high for dealers purely because that is where demand letters actually land. D3

D Security & Compliance

The most sharply differentiated section after Conversion, and the difference is regulatory, not technical (D3). Anyone who takes a credit application handles SSNs and falls under the GLBA Safeguards Rule; anyone who advertises APR or a lease payment falls under Reg-Z / Reg-M and the FTC CARS Rule. A garage advertising a \$99 brake special carries almost none of that. Transport and reputation stay Critical for everyone because they are gates.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
HTTPS + no mixed content	3 3 3 3	Hard gate. Missing HTTPS caps the whole section regardless of anything else passing.
SSL certificate validity	3 3 3 3	Expired or mismatched certificate produces a browser interstitial — total traffic loss for every site type.
SSL expiry window	2 2 2 2	Early warning on the above. Same value everywhere.
TLS version	2 2 2 2	TLS 1.2 minimum. Legacy protocol support is a compliance finding on any site.
HSTS	2 2 2 1	Strongest justification where a session can carry financial PII; a brochure garage site has less to protect in transit. D3
Content-Security-Policy	3 2 2 1	Franchise dealer sites run the heaviest third-party tag stack in local retail — chat, CRM, inventory widget, trade tool, several tag managers — so the injection surface is genuinely largest there, and it sits on the same origin as the credit application. D3 · D4
X-Frame-Options / frame-ancestors	2 2 1 1	Clickjacking a credit application or trade valuator has real value to an attacker; clickjacking a booking page has much less. D3
X-Content-Type-Options	2 2 1 1	One header, always worth setting; consequence scales with the value of what is on the page.
Referrer-Policy	2 2 1 1	A permissive policy leaks credit-application and VDP URLs (with query parameters) to every third-party script on the page. D3
Permissions-Policy	1 1 1 1	Low impact in this vertical; worth setting, rarely decisive.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Cookie flags (Secure/HttpOnly/SameSite)	2 2 2 1	Matters most where a session can be tied to a submitted finance application. D3
Third-party cookies	2 2 1 1	Dealer sites carry the most third-party tracking, and 'Do Not Sell' obligations attach to lead data specifically. D3
Reputation — Safe Browsing / VirusTotal / blacklist	3 3 3 3	Hard gate. A malware or phishing flag caps the section for every site type and removes the site from search results entirely.
SQL-injection surface indicator	2 2 1 1	Inventory search takes user-supplied parameters into a database query, which is the one genuinely dynamic input surface these sites have. Service/repair sites are usually static. D1
XSS surface indicator	2 2 1 1	Same reasoning — reflected search terms on an SRP are the usual reflection point. D1
Forms use HTTPS	3 3 3 2	A credit application or trade form posting over HTTP is a reportable finding. A repair site with only a contact form is lower-consequence but still fails. D3
Weak default credentials	2 2 2 2	Active login testing. Equally applicable; findings cluster on self-hosted WordPress.
Admin panel public exposure	2 2 2 3	Repair and small service sites are the most likely to be self-built WordPress with /wp-admin and /wp-login.php wide open and no rate limiting. D4
MFA posture	1 1 1 1	Only meaningful where a customer login surface exists, which is uncommon on all four.
Cookie consent banner	2 2 2 2	Required wherever non-essential cookies fire before consent — true for all four, most acute for dealers under GDPR/CCPA. D3
Privacy policy link	3 3 2 2	Mandatory where financial PII is collected. Dealers taking credit applications in the US are financial institutions under GLBA and must publish a privacy notice. D3
GDPR / CCPA / Do-Not-Sell disclosure	3 3 2 2	Dealers monetise lead data, which is exactly what 'Do Not Sell or Share My Personal Information' addresses. Service and repair typically do not sell leads onward. D3
Finance-form PII security	3 3 - -	SSN and income fields must be HTTPS POST, never in a GET query string, with no sensitive autocomplete leakage. Both dealer types run credit applications; neither service nor repair collects this class of data. D1 · D3
Legal / financial disclaimers (Reg-Z, Reg-M, FTC CARS)	3 3 2 1	Franchise dealers advertise APR and lease terms and are directly exposed to Reg-Z and Reg-M. Independent lots are the primary target of the FTC's CARS Rule on advertised pricing and add-ons. Service coupons need only T&Cs; repair shops rarely advertise credit terms at all. D3
Header security grade (info)	2 2 2 2	Observatory-style comparable sub-grade. Reporting value, not an independent control.

E UX & Content Structure

Splits along task complexity. Dealers ask the visitor to search, filter, compare and configure, so navigation, filtering and gallery quality carry the section. Service and repair ask the visitor to understand a problem and then call or book, so readability and above-the-fold clarity carry it instead.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Text readability	2 2 3 3	Service and repair have to explain a mechanical problem to a non-mechanic before they can sell the fix. Dealer copy is largely specification data, which is read, not comprehended. D6
Intrusive interstitials	3 3 2 2	Dealer sites routinely stack a chat proactive, an offer modal and a newsletter popup over the same viewport — a Google interstitial penalty and a measurable bounce driver. D2
Navigation discoverability	3 3 2 2	A franchise site has 8–12 top-level destinations and a mega-menu; a garage site has five links and is self-evident. Nav failures cost proportionally to IA depth. D4
Above-the-fold content	3 3 3 3	Universal. For repair it is specifically 'phone number and what you fix, visible without scrolling'. D2
Broken links	3 3 2 2	Inventory churn manufactures dead links continuously — every sold vehicle orphans links from SRPs, blog posts and specials pages. Static sites accumulate them far more slowly. D1 · D4
Mobile experience	3 3 3 3	Universal, and the majority traffic mode for all four. Non-negotiable everywhere. D2
Interactive click feedback	1 1 1 1	Hover/active/focus states. Polish, not conversion-critical.
Loading feedback	2 2 1 1	Asynchronous inventory and filter results need skeletons or spinners; a static service menu does not. D1
Hierarchy & flow clarity	2 2 2 2	Scannable structure and labelled sections. Flat across types.
Content density balance	1 1 1 1	Text-to-element ratio. Low leverage everywhere.
Layout consistency	2 2 1 1	Template consistency across thousands of generated VDPs is a real quality signal. A 15-page site is consistent by construction. D4

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Sticky-header height	2 2 2 2	Obscured content and focus on mobile. Equal across types.
In-page navigation (anchors, back-to-top)	2 2 2 2	Long VDP specification pages and long service menus both benefit; roughly equal value.
Breadcrumbs	3 2 2 1	Depth navigation and BreadcrumbList schema matter most where the path is Home → SRP → filtered SRP → VDP. A garage's deepest path is two levels. D4
Inventory filtering usability	3 3 - -	The core task on an SRP: filter clarity, applied-filter visibility, live result counts, clear-all and URL-stable filters. No inventory means no filters. D1
No-results UX	3 3 - -	Rated equally high for independents specifically because a small lot hits zero-result searches far more often than a 900-car franchise store — recovering that dead end into a lead is worth more, not less. D1
Vehicle image gallery quality	3 3 - -	Photo count, resolution and real-versus-stock detection. For an independent used lot this is the strongest available trust signal — stock manufacturer photography on a used car reads as concealment. D1 · D5

F Conversion & Lead Flow

The most differentiated section in the product, and the reason a single automotive profile cannot serve all four types. The lead mechanism is genuinely different: form for dealers, scheduler for service, telephone for repair (D2). Trust also inverts — a franchise dealer borrows the OEM's credibility, everyone else has to manufacture it (D5).

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
CTA presence / visibility	3 3 3 3	Universal. Only the wording changes: 'Check Availability' versus 'Book a Service' versus 'Call Now'. D2
CTA clarity / messaging	3 3 3 3	Action verbs and funnel-appropriate labelling. Equally critical on all four. D2
CTA crowding	3 3 2 1	A dealer VDP routinely presents eight competing primary CTAs in one viewport — value trade, get ePrice, check availability, schedule test drive, apply for finance, calculate payment, chat, call. Choice paralysis is a dealer-specific disease. D2
CTA flow alignment / funnel placement	3 3 2 2	Rendered-geometry check: is the right CTA above the fold and repeated at the decision point. Highest value where the funnel has multiple stages. D2
Form presence	3 3 3 2	Expected on trade, finance, contact and service pages. On a repair site the absence of a form is often a deliberate, correct choice — the phone is the funnel. D2
Form length / field count	3 3 2 2	Every extra field on a credit application or trade valuator measurably reduces completion. A four-field booking form has less to trim. D2
Required vs optional fields	2 2 2 2	Friction control. Consistent value across types.
Inline validation	2 2 2 1	Value rises with form length, so it tracks the credit application.
Submit-button clarity	2 2 2 2	'Get My Trade Value' beats 'Submit' on every site type.
Multi-step form progress	2 2 1 1	Credit applications and trade valuations are genuinely multi-step. Booking is usually one screen. D2
Friendly error handling	2 2 2 1	Proportional to form complexity.
Microcopy clarity	2 2 2 1	Reassurance text next to PII fields ('this will not affect your credit score') is worth the most on finance forms.
Thank-you page / lead confirmation	2 2 2 1	Needed for conversion tracking as much as for UX; matters wherever a form exists.
Trust badges	2 3 2 2	Independent lots need visible security and accreditation marks next to a PII form more than a franchise store, which is already trading on the manufacturer's badge. D5
Testimonials	2 3 3 3	A franchise dealer inherits brand trust. An independent lot, a service chain and a garage are chosen almost entirely on other customers' word. D5
Reviews / ratings visibility	3 3 3 3	Universal in automotive retail and service; star ratings also feed AI answers and the local pack, so this is a dual-purpose signal everywhere. D5
Client / partner logos	1 2 2 2	Lender panels for independents, NAPA AutoCare / Bosch Service / OEM-approved marks for service and repair. A franchise dealer's single OEM badge already does this job. D5
Case studies / success stories	1 1 1 2	Body shops and specialist mechanics convert on before-and-after work galleries, which is the closest thing to a case study in this vertical. D5

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Certifications & awards	2 2 3 3	ASE, I-CAR, RAA, MTA, VACC, RACV approval is the core credibility currency in service and repair — a customer cannot evaluate mechanical competence directly, so they use accreditation as a proxy. D5
Pricing transparency	3 3 3 3	For dealers: no 'call for price', fees disclosed. For service and repair, published pricing is the single strongest differentiator in a market built on opacity — but the engine currently only runs this check on VDP, Offers, Lease and Finance pages, so it never fires on a service or repair site. D5
Vehicle history report (CARFAX / AutoCheck)	2 3 - -	Rated higher for independent lots than franchise stores: with no manufacturer-certified pre-owned programme to point at, a VIN-specific history report is the primary objection handler. D5
Click-to-call	2 3 3 3	The phone is the primary conversion mechanism for service and repair and a major one for used lots. A telephone number rendered as unlinked text on mobile is a direct lost lead. D2
Chat experience	2 2 2 1	Standard on dealer platforms, useful for service, usually noise on a small garage site. D2
Lead magnets	1 1 1 1	Price alerts, buying guides, maintenance schedules. Soft conversion, low weight everywhere.
GA4 installed	3 3 3 2	Measurability is the precondition for optimisation. Slightly lower on repair only because many such sites have no analytics at all and a phone call is measured by the phone.
GTM configuration	2 2 2 1	Container present and non-empty. Tracks GA4.
Conversion tracking	3 3 3 2	Form-submit, call and chat events. For service and repair specifically, call tracking is the conversion tracking that matters. D2
CRM integration	2 2 2 1	VinSolutions / DealerSocket / eLead wiring on dealer sites; service schedulers on chains. Rarely present on independent garages. D2
Trade-in flow / valuation tool	3 3 - -	The reason the trade-in page exists, and one of the two highest-intent lead types in retail automotive. Absent by definition on service and repair. D1 · D2
Financing flow / pre-approval	3 3 - -	Credit application and lender pre-qualification. Present on both dealer types — independents lean subprime and buy-here-pay-here, but the page and its risks are the same. D1 · D2
Finance / payment calculator	3 2 - -	Franchise stores advertise APR and lease payments and need a real calculator; independent lots more often quote weekly buy-here-pay-here figures where a calculator is less central. D1
Appointment booking scheduler	2 1 3 3	The entire funnel for service and repair — date picker, service-type selection, vehicle details. Franchise dealers have a service department so it matters secondarily; independent lots usually have none. D1 · D2
Incentives / specials displayed	3 2 3 2	OEM incentives and manufacturer rebates for franchise stores; service coupons and seasonal offers for service centres. Independent lots and garages run fewer time-bound offers. D2

G AIO — AI Optimisation (ingestion)

Machine ingestibility. The universal failure here is identical across all four types — content that only exists after client-side JavaScript runs is invisible to crawlers that do not render. Beyond that, dealers need entity precision (make/model/trim naming) and freshness (inventory turns weekly); service and repair need answer-shaped structure because their queries are questions.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Structured-data validity	3 3 3 3	JSON-LD that parses, matches visible content and carries required properties. Universal Critical — only the schema type changes between site types.
Content NLP-friendly (server-rendered, semantic)	3 3 3 3	Universal and the most common serious defect. A JavaScript-only inventory grid or service menu simply does not exist to a non-rendering crawler or LLM.
Answer-oriented structure	2 2 3 3	Service and repair content is inherently question-shaped ('why is my brake pedal soft', 'how often should I change the timing belt'), so question-headed self-contained blocks map directly onto how those pages get ingested. D6
Keywords / entities annotated	2 3 2 2	Independent lots carry mixed-brand inventory with inconsistent make/model/trim naming from multiple feeds, which is exactly what breaks entity extraction. Franchise stores inherit a consistent OEM vocabulary. D6
Content updated regularly / freshness markers	3 3 2 2	Inventory turns weekly, so dateModified, visible updated dates and Last-Modified headers carry genuine information on dealer sites. A service menu changes twice a year. D1
Internal linking AI-friendly (crawlable anchors)	3 2 2 1	JavaScript onclick navigation instead of real anchors hides inventory from every non-rendering ingest path, and the cost scales with how many pages are hidden. D4
Topical focus clarity	2 2 3 3	One topic per page with aligned title, H1 and URL. Service and repair sites are the ones that tend to pile every service onto one page. D6

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
AI agentic browsing / WebMCP readiness	2 2 2 1	Early-mover signal. Highest theoretical value where an agent could transact — searching inventory, valuing a trade, booking a service — and near zero on a brochure garage site. D6
Duplicate-content readiness (info)	3 2 1 1	Canonical and noindex used correctly so an ingesting model sees one version. Informational here because On-Page SEO owns and grades canonicals more thoroughly. D4
Structured content — lists & tables (info)	2 2 3 3	Service price tables and maintenance-interval tables are exactly the format answer engines extract from. Dealer specification tables serve the same purpose on VDPs. D6
Terminology consistency (info)	2 2 2 2	Consistent naming of models, services and locations across the site. Informational, equal value.

H AEO — Answer Engine Optimisation

The section where service and repair systematically outrank dealers in importance. Their customers ask questions that AI answer engines now answer directly, and a local business with no brand equity gains the most from being the cited source. Dealers gain from schema and index coverage — being present as structured inventory — more than from being quoted.

PARAMETER	1 2 3 4	WHY THIS PATTERN
Schema markup (page-appropriate type)	3 3 3 3	Universal Critical, but the required type differs completely: AutoDealer + Vehicle + Offer + ItemList for dealers; AutoRepair + Service + Offer + LocalBusiness for service and repair. Marking a repair shop up as an AutoDealer is a real and common error.
Answer-first structure / TL;DR lead	2 2 3 3	A direct answer in the first 40–60 words is what gets lifted into an AI answer. Service and repair queries have answers; 'inventory near me' does not. D6
Bot access (GPTBot, Google-Extended, PerplexityBot)	3 3 3 3	Universal. Blocking these agents in robots.txt removes the site from AI answers entirely — a self-inflicted wound that is equally fatal on all four types.
Structured content (tables / lists)	3 3 3 3	Machine-parseable specification tables on VDPs and service price tables on service pages. Specifications rendered as an image are invisible on every site type. D6
FAQ / Q&A blocks + FAQPage schema	2 2 3 3	Service and repair questions are the highest-volume automotive query class in AI answers — cost, symptom, interval, warranty. Dealers get most FAQ value only on finance pages. D6
Entity recognition (Organization / LocalBusiness)	2 3 3 3	A franchise dealer is already an established entity via the OEM's dealer locator and the manufacturer's own structured data. Independent lots, service chains and garages must establish identity themselves. D5
Citation / NAP consistency	2 3 3 3	The local pack is the dominant discovery surface for service and repair, and it is gated on name, address and phone matching exactly across the site and Google Business Profile. D5 · D6
Citations / outbound attribution	1 1 2 2	Linking to NHTSA, IIHS, OEM service intervals or manufacturer specifications raises the credibility of an explanatory page. Dealers rarely publish that kind of content. D6
Topical authority / clustering	2 2 3 3	Depth across a coherent topic set — a repair shop covering every brake symptom, cost and interval builds a citable cluster. Dealer inventory pages do not cluster topically. D6
Index coverage	3 2 2 2	Are the money pages actually indexed. At 40,000 URLs with faceted duplicates this is a genuine and frequently failing constraint; a 15-page site is either indexed or has a much simpler problem. D4
sameAs validation	2 2 3 3	Resolvable, name-matching profile links (GBP, Facebook, Yelp, DealerRater, Trustpilot) are how an engine confirms a small local business is the one being asked about. D5
E-E-A-T composite	2 2 3 3	For a repair shop, E-E-A-T is technician credentials, years in trade, workshop accreditation and named authors — and it is the only defence against being replaced by a generic AI answer. Dealers carry OEM authority instead. D5 · D6
llms.txt	1 1 1 1	Emerging, low adoption, cheap to add. Equal marginal value; ChatGPT weights it heavily in the platform matrix, so it is the cheapest AEO win available on all four.
Brand entity strength (info)	1 2 2 2	Informational to avoid double-counting entity recognition. Reads lowest for franchise dealers because the OEM supplies the brand strength. D5
Markdown headers / clear heading structure (info)	1 1 2 2	Informational. Heavily weighted inside the ChatGPT platform score, which favours explanatory service and repair content. D6
Page-speed signal in AEO (info)	1 1 1 1	Informational by design — owned by Technical Performance and never weighted twice.
Platform scores — Gemini / ChatGPT / Perplexity	2 2 3 3	Per-engine roll-up. Rated higher for service and repair because a larger share of their total addressable demand is now resolved inside an AI answer rather than a click. D6

Where the engine cannot yet act on this

Seven places where what this matrix says a site type needs and what Backend/metricServices/ actually measures diverge. Ordered by how much score distortion each one causes today.

Pricing transparency is VDP/Offers/Lease/Finance-scoped **SERVICE, REPAIR**

checkPricingTransparency only runs when the page classifies as vdp, specials, lease or finance. Published service pricing is arguably the strongest differentiator on a service or repair site and is currently never measured there.

Fix → Extend the page-type gate to include service, and score 'is a price or price range published for each named service'.

Appointment booking is service-page-scoped only **REPAIR**

checkAppointmentBooking runs only when classifyPageType returns 'service'. A repair shop's booking form frequently sits on the home page or a /book page that classifies as generic, so the single most important conversion parameter for that site type goes unscored.

Fix → Run the booking check on home and generic pages when the site type is service or repair.

No site-type sub-classification **ALL FOUR**

siteTypeDetector returns only dealer / corporate / unknown. All four of the types in this report collapse into 'dealer', so a garage is scored against a franchise dealer's expectations — including inventory, trade-in and finance parameters that it correctly does not have.

Fix → Add a sub-type resolver (franchise / independent / service / repair) and key a parameter-applicability profile off it, the same way SECTION_PAGE_WEIGHTS is keyed off page type today.

Local SEO signals largely unimplemented **SERVICE, REPAIR (MOST), DEALER (INDEPENDENT)**

NAP consistency exists only inside AEO's citationConsistency signal. Google Business Profile linkage, location-page completeness, local landing pages and review signals are not measured at all — and they are the dominant discovery surface for exactly the two site types that need them most.

Fix → Add a Local SEO parameter group scored only for service, repair and independent-dealer site types.

Service / AutoRepair schema not type-validated **SERVICE, REPAIR**

Structured-data validation covers Organization, LocalBusiness, Product, Offer, Vehicle, FAQPage, BreadcrumbList, Article and Review. AutoRepair, AutomotiveBusiness and Service are not in the required-field validator, so a repair site marked up correctly and a repair site marked up as a generic LocalBusiness score the same.

Fix → Add AutoRepair / AutoPartsStore / Service to the per-@type required-property validator, and flag AutoDealer markup on a site with no inventory as a type mismatch.

Certifications & awards is a generic check **SERVICE, REPAIR**

checkCertificationsAwards looks for award-like language generically. For service and repair the specific accreditations (ASE, I-CAR, NAPA AutoCare, Bosch Service, RAA, MTA, VACC, RACV) are the credibility currency and deserve a named list.

Fix → Add a trade-accreditation dictionary keyed by market, reusing the country config already added in Frontend/src/config/countries.js.

Call tracking not distinguished from conversion tracking **SERVICE, REPAIR**

checkConversionTracking looks for form-submit and generic events. Where the phone is the funnel, the meaningful check is whether a call-tracking number or a tel: click event is wired to analytics.

Fix → Split a call-tracking sub-check out of Conversion_Tracking and weight it up for service and repair site types.

• How to wire this in

1. **Add a site sub-type to the detector.** `dealershipDetector.js` already collects the signals needed to separate these — inventory and VIN presence separates dealer from service; OEM-franchise language, lease programmes and a manufacturer logo separate franchise from independent; a booking scheduler with no inventory separates service from repair. Return `siteSubType`: `'franchise' | 'independent' | 'service' | 'repair'` alongside the existing `siteType`, keeping the current fail-open behaviour when signals are inconclusive.
2. **Encode applicability, not just weight.** Add an `appliesTo[siteSubType]` flag to each parameter beside the existing per-page-type gating. The renormalising roll-up already in place then removes N/A parameters from the denominator for free — no scoring change needed.
3. **Key a site-type section profile off it**, multiplying into `SECTION_PAGE_WEIGHTS` rather than replacing it.
4. **Adjust page discovery expectations.** `pageDiscovery.js` currently looks for SRP and VDP pages on every site. On a service or repair sub-type it should look for service-menu, booking, location and pricing pages instead, and not report missing inventory as a finding.
5. **Do the three cheap coverage fixes first** — pricing transparency on service pages, booking detection outside `/service`, and AutoRepair schema validation. Between them they cover the three highest-rated parameters that a service or repair site currently cannot score on at all.

Parameter inventory read from the implemented return objects of `technicalMetrics.js`, `seoMetrics.js`, `accessibilityMetrics.js`, `securityCompliance.js`, `uxContentStructure.js`, `conversionLeadFlow.js`, `aioReadiness.js` and `aeoService.js`, cross-checked against `docs/specs/AUDIT_FRAMEWORK_SPECIFICATION.md`. Informational (weight-0) parameters are included and labelled, because they still appear in the report the customer reads.